ERA 18

The Road to War

1931 – 1941

Isolationism · aggression · Pearl Harbor

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did the United States move from isolationism to a world war?

KEY TERMS

The Neutrality Acts · appeasement · Cash & Carry · Lend-Lease · the Atlantic Charter · Pearl Harbor

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 7.11 · AMSCO Ch. 7.11

FROM ISOLATION TO INTERVENTION

The Road to War

The Interwar Retreat

I

Isolationism

Disillusioned by WWI, most Americans wanted to stay out of foreign wars.

II

The Nye Committee

Hearings blamed WWI on greedy bankers and arms makers—'merchants of death.'

III

The Neutrality Acts

Laws (1935–1937) banned arms sales and loans to warring nations.

Aggression on the March

I

Japan & Italy

Japan seized **Manchuria** (1931); Italy invaded **Ethiopia** (1935).

II

Nazi Germany

Hitler rearmed and seized the Rhineland, Austria, and the **Sudetenland**.

III

Appeasement Fails

At **Munich**, Britain and France gave in—Hitler only demanded more.

War Erupts in Europe

- Germany's **invasion of Poland** (September 1939) began World War II.
- **Blitzkrieg** overran Poland and France; Britain stood nearly alone.
- The **Axis Powers** now menaced all of Europe.



SECTION

The End of Neutrality

The Arsenal of Democracy



- '**Cash and Carry**' (1939) let the Allies buy U.S. arms—if they paid and carried them.
- **Lend-Lease** (1941) lent weapons to Britain—America became the 'arsenal of democracy.'
- The **America First** movement fought to keep the U.S. out.

The Atlantic Charter

- **Roosevelt** and **Churchill** met secretly at sea in 1941.
- They issued the **Atlantic Charter**—a statement of Allied war aims.
- The U.S. was neutral in name only.



SECTION

Pearl Harbor

'A Date Which Will Live in Infamy'



- The U.S. cut off oil to Japan to protest its expansion in Asia.
- On December 7, 1941, Japan attacked the U.S. fleet at **Pearl Harbor**.
- The next day, a united America declared war—entering World War II.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Road to War

1. Disillusioned by WWI, America embraced **isolationism** and passed the **Neutrality Acts**.
2. As the **Axis Powers** conquered Europe and Asia, the U.S. shifted to aiding the Allies through **Cash & Carry** and **Lend-Lease**.
3. The Japanese attack on **Pearl Harbor** ended the debate—and brought America into the war.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Road to War

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain why the U.S. clung to **isolationism** in the 1930s—and how that changed.

COMPARISON

Compare U.S. neutrality before **World War I** and before **World War II**.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

How did **Pearl Harbor** transform American public opinion overnight?

Up next — **Lesson 43: The Theaters of War** (Europe, the Pacific & the atomic bomb)